

UNIFORMS AND INSIGNIA OF 19TH-CENTURY ARMIES

The taste for elaborate, colourful, and imposing uniforms established by European armies in the Napoleonic era influenced the outfitting of soldiers throughout the 19th century. The French army under Napoleon Bonaparte is often celebrated as the high point of style and decoration in military uniforms, but – if anything – uniforms became even more intricately embellished and detailed in the decades following his defeat in 1815. Right through until the eve of World War I, in 1914, many armies were clad in distinctive uniforms in traditional colours, featuring outmoded elements of equipment, such as the sabretache.

► BRITISH BELL-TOP SHAKO

Date 1830
Origin UK
Material Felt, leather, brass

This cavalryman's bell-top shako – designed to make the wearer look taller and more imposing – was one of several rather impractical designs of the period that followed the highly ornamented “Regency” shako of 1822.



Horsehair plume

▼ BRITISH CAVALRY OFFICER'S SABRETACHE

Date 1830
Origin UK
Material Leather

British cavalry wore the sabretache – a leather bag suspended from a cavalryman's belt – from the late 1700s onwards. In the 1800s, the sabretache was often restricted to ceremonial wear, but British cavalry wore it in the Crimean War (1853–56).



“Bursting grenade” emblem

▲ BRITISH CAVALRYMAN'S EPAULETTES

Date 1830
Origin UK
Material Wool, metallic thread

These epaulettes were probably worn by a cavalryman in the “Scots Greys” (officially the 2nd Dragoons), who were celebrated for their mounted charge at the Battle of Waterloo. The “bursting grenade” emblem, originally belonging to the Grenadiers, was associated with elite regiments.



Embroidered cover

▼ BRITISH INFANTRY CORPORAL'S DRESS COAT

Date c.1850
Origin India
Material Wool

This coat was worn by a corporal in the East India Company's 2nd European Light Regiment. The regiment served in the Anglo-Persian War of 1856–57, and became part of the British Army in 1862.



Corporal's stripes

Four buttons on cuff